

Vaccinating Against the “Gender War”: Gender-Expansive Early Education as a Strategy to Reduce Youth Gender Polarization

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December 2025

1 Introduction

For ages, the definition of gender relations has revolved around people’s understanding of gender roles: men as breadwinners, women as homemakers. Since the first and second waves of feminism, women have gained greater agency in both private and public sectors. That’s great—those who want to work can pursue careers. The reality, however, is that many women inhabit a liminal space—having entered public professional life while remaining psychologically and practically engaged in the private sphere of reproductive labour. While women hesitate to fully commit, men’s attitudes toward this transformation are intriguing. Like any privileged group facing upheaval, men struggle to confront the dissolution of an identity built upon a system of privilege.

Cooperation or revolution? That is the question. Yet conflict remains the perennial theme. In the age of social media, the conflicts arising from this shift in power have been amplified. In a world where seeking a lifelong partner remains the norm, sometimes within the framework of marriage, people have paradoxically begun to fear forming connections with others. If adults who grew up with normal in-person contact still feel unrest and lonely, then what about children immersed in this environment from childhood? What does their future hold? It is a transitional time where both the decline and backlash of traditional gender roles are present. When we observe a sequence of non-cooperative equilibria — low marriage rates, low fertility rates — we must raise this question: Is low collaboration the desirable outcome? Or is the framework simply outdated, given the current situation?

But the most crucial question is: how can we help the next generation navigate towards healthy relationships between different genders during this social upheaval, at a time when a growing share of young men and women are withdrawing from cooperation — in household formation, in labour markets, and in politics — rather than renegotiating the terms? I want to argue that, instead of focusing only on the downstream consequences of gender norms — sexism, toxic masculinity, the wage gap and so on — we should intervene where these norms are first formed: early childhood. A growing body of research shows that gender stereotypes begin shaping children’s beliefs and behaviour from a very young age. Gender-expansive preschool education is designed precisely for this window. It does not try to erase gender, but to widen the

set of scripts available to children, showing that care, curiosity, leadership and competence are not owned by any one gender. In doing so, it not only broadens children's option sets over the life course, but also generates positive externalities in the form of lower acceptance of gender-based violence.

2 Gender Conflict as Misallocation

2.1 From gender conflict to a bad political economic equilibrium

At first glance, contemporary “gender wars” resemble classic political–economic conflicts, where two groups contest the distribution of resources, status and risks. Feminist scholars have long documented how patriarchal institutions allocate unpaid care work, labour market opportunities and political voice asymmetrically between men and women. In that sense, gender relations are not merely “cultural”; They structure who bears the cost of reproduction and who captures the returns of market production, much like historical conflicts between landed elites and the broader population over taxation and property rights.

Yet gender conflict is also fundamentally different from standard class or elite–mass struggles in at least three respects. First, membership is universal and interdependent. Men and women are not spatially separable blocs; instead, they live together in families, workplaces and intimate relationships, and neither side can simply secede from the other. This makes revolutionary “replacement” of one group by another both conceptually and practically implausible. Instead, conflict often takes the form of withdrawal from marriage and fertility, rising mistrust and online polarization rather than outright regime change.

Second, the underlying hierarchy is highly naturalized and enacted in the private sphere. Whereas aristocracies historically extracted rents through explicit legal privileges and visible taxes, many of the benefits men receive under patriarchy are dispersed across everyday life: unpaid domestic labour, emotional support, reproductive risks absorbed by women, and subtle advantages in hiring and promotion. These are justified not as deliberate extraction but as “natural” differences in aptitude and role, for example: “men are just better at leadership roles”. As a result, many men experience contemporary gender reforms not as a partial correction of inherited privilege, but as an inexplicable loss of status and security—fuel for zero-sum narratives rather than for negotiated compromise.

Third, the main institutional arena is the family and intimate partnership, rather than only parliaments or unions. Marriage and household arrangements simultaneously allocate resources, ensure against shocks and reproduce norms. When this institution is strained by changing gender roles, the consequences spill over into welfare states, labour markets and demographic trends. However, because these struggles are coded as “private,” they often escape the kinds of explicit bargaining and pact-making that political economy models assume among organized classes or elites.

Taken together, these features mean that contemporary gender conflict is best understood as a political economic distributional struggle that is unusually intimate, naturalized and misrecognized. The stakes are no less material than in classic class

conflict, but the actors often lack a clear sense of what they are bargaining over. This helps explain why, in the age of social media, much of the energy is channelled into emotionally charged “gender war” narratives rather than into cooperative renegotiation of norms and institutions. Within such a structure, and in the absence of explicit renegotiation of norms and institutions, contemporary gender conflict can be seen as a bad equilibrium of non-cooperation.

2.2 A transitional regime with misallocation

The current gender regime can be seen as an adjustment process with large frictions. Institutions such as marriage and the nuclear family were designed around an older gendered division of labour, and they still tend to reward those who conform to traditional roles while penalizing those who deviate, for example, full-time fathers, women who remain single, or couples who try to share breadwinning and care on more equal terms. These institutional and social frictions slow down movement towards a new, more efficient allocation and pull many households back toward familiar gendered scripts, even when all parties are dissatisfied with the outcome.

In this sense, the transitional phase is not neutral drift but a systematic misallocation of human capital and bargaining power. Faced with uncertain norms and incomplete institutional support, both men and women often retreat from cooperation to avoid perceived losses of status, for instance, by delaying partnership, withdrawing from joint economic planning, or reverting to more traditional specialization as a form of insurance. At the same time, children and adolescents learn gendered heuristics about “what people like me do,” and then voluntarily narrow their choice sets by stepping away from educational and occupational paths that would raise their productivity or outside options. This is not only a problem of individual frustration, but it also lowers aggregate output and the future tax base.

From an early age, girls and boys are taught differently about what they should be good at; This gendered discipline operates subtly, functioning more like an unspoken taboo. Precisely because these norms remain concealed, their influence often manifests in individuals’ self-confidence and the choices they make regarding opportunities. Or, to put it in the economic jargon, it causes children to voluntarily narrow their own option sets, when they don’t know if it is for better or worse.

Girls: domesticity norms and the narrowing of options

Experimental and longitudinal studies show that gendered stereotypes about mathematical ability shape girls’ self-assessments and career aspirations, even when their measured performance matches that of boys. In laboratory and survey experiments, exposure to the belief that “men are better at math” leads women to rate their own math competence lower and to express less interest in quantitative fields despite equal scores [[Correll \(2001\)](#)]. Cross-country and cohort evidence further suggests that girls’ relative reading advantage, combined with gendered expectations about “appropriate” fields, steers many capable girls away from math-intensive, high-pay occupations such as STEM and finance [[Breda and Napp \(2019\)](#), [Eccles \(2011\)](#)]. In other words, well before labour-market entry, gendered norms are already narrowing girls’

perceived option sets in precisely those domains that carry the highest long-run returns.

The pitfalls of such gender narratives do not prey solely upon vulnerable children. They frequently manifest in the early stages of young adulthood as well. Social media “tradwife” cultures further aestheticize this pattern by repackaging highly unequal risk-sharing (single-earner dependence, unpaid care, weak exit options) as an aspirational lifestyle, and obscuring the underlying economic vulnerability. A large empirical literature shows that gender norms systematically shape women’s life-cycle labour choices and earnings. Women socialized in more traditional environments are less likely to participate in the labour force and more likely to specialize in unpaid care, even conditional on skills and education [Fernández and Fogli (2009); Fernández et al. (2004)]. Quasi-experimental evidence on “child penalties” further shows that women, particularly around childbirth, sort into more flexible and “family-friendly” jobs and suffer large, persistent earnings losses relative to men [Kleven et al. (2019), Goldin (2014)]. Recent general-equilibrium work formalizes these patterns as a “norm wedge” on married women’s work that pushes the economy into a low-output equilibrium with under-used female talent [Lee (2025)]. Domesticity norms operate as a life-course mechanism that channels female human capital into lower-paid, higher-care trajectories, weakening women’s outside options in both labour and marriage markets and reducing aggregate output. These mechanisms do not simply reflect individual ‘preferences’, but a systematic distortion of human-capital investment and risk-sharing decisions induced by gendered norms

Boys: anti-school masculinity and fragile trajectories.

A parallel misallocation operates on boys and young men, but through a different normative channel. Across many countries, families, peer groups and media promote an “anti-school” masculinity in which academic diligence, deference to teachers and help-seeking are coded as unmasculine [Jackson (2002, 2003); Geven et al. (2017)]. Ethnographic and survey evidence shows that boys who endorse more patriarchal or hegemonic gender-role orientations are more likely to adopt “laddish” behaviours—downplaying effort, disrupting class and distancing themselves from school as a way to protect masculine self-worth—and these patterns are strongly associated with school alienation and lower grades and attainment [Hadjar et al. (2015)].

Because teachers’ assessments often reward not only cognitive performance but also “good student” behaviours such as compliance, organization and cooperation, which are culturally feminized, this behavioural pattern feeds directly into educational [Jones and Myhill (2004); Duckworth and Seligman (2006); DiPrete and Jennings (2012); Kaiser et al. (2013)]. A large empirical literature comparing blindly graded standardized tests with teacher-assigned grades finds that girls receive systematically higher teacher evaluations than boys with similar test scores, and that a significant share of this gap is mediated by non-cognitive skills and teachers’ gendered expectations of diligence and conduct [Cornwell et al. (2013); Terrier (2020); Lievore and Triventi (2023); Doornkamp et al. (2022); Lehti et al. (2024)].

These dynamics contribute to the now well-documented reversal of the gender gap in education: in most high- and middle-income countries, young men are less likely than young women to complete secondary school or enroll in tertiary educa-

tion, and globally, only about 88 men are enrolled in higher education for every 100 women [Buchmann et al. (2008); UNESCO (2022); UNESCO Institute for Statistics (2023)]. In parallel, traditional masculinity norms push boys away from so-called HEED occupations—health, early education and domestic care—that are culturally coded as feminine but provide relatively stable employment in ageing, service-based economies; male entrants into these fields still report stigma, gendered occupational stereotypes and a constant need to defend their masculinity [Simpson (2005); Croft et al. (2015)].

Finally, the same dominance-oriented norms that devalue school and care work are also implicated in gender-based violence and extremist online subcultures. Work on school-related gender-based violence and the so-called “Man Box” – encouraging aggression, emotional suppression and control over women – shows that boys who strongly endorse rigid masculine norms are more likely to engage in bullying and violence against girls and other boys, and also face higher risks of mental health problems and conflict with the law [Fleming et al. (2020)].

Session Summary

In summary, these patterns suggest that girls and boys are not on opposite sides of a zero-sum gender war, but are being channelled into different, equally constraining tracks of the same misallocation equilibrium. For girls, “going along with the system” – working hard at school, avoiding conflict, choosing family-friendly jobs – often means internalizing gendered expectations that quietly steer them toward lower-paid, more precarious forms of work and a heavier unpaid care burden, with weaker outside options in the marriage market over the life-cycle. For boys, “pushing back against the system” – distancing themselves from school, performing toughness and emotional invulnerability, rejecting feminized careers – can feel like a way to defend status, yet it feeds into lower attainment, higher risks of dropout and exclusion, and a narrower set of viable occupations in an economy where care and service jobs are precisely the ones expanding.

Females’ and males’ dilemmas are two faces of the same structural problem. Gendered norms for women operate mainly through education and labour supply, depressing female human-capital investment and labour-force attachment and thereby lowering aggregate output and the future tax base. Harmful masculine norms for men operate more through violence, risk-taking and mental health, effectively “burning” male human capital in the form of higher rates of injury, incarceration and premature mortality, with sizeable health, justice and productivity costs. In summary, they do not produce a world in which one gender clearly “wins”; they generate a large, persistent misallocation of talent and risk across the population, reducing overall welfare and making cooperative reforms to gender relations harder to sustain.

3 Empirical Evidence and Rationale for Early Intervention

3.1 Trends of polarization and gender-based violence, at what cost?

Across advanced democracies, recent research documents a growing ideological gender gap among young people, especially in those countries with greater gen-

der equality [Nennstiel and Hudde (2025)]. The trend continues in the labour market, where men and women are introduced as competitors. Evidence from 27 EU countries further shows that young men who feel more exposed to labour-market competition from women are significantly more opposed to gender equality policies than both older men and young women [Alexander et al. (2025)]. These attitudinal divides matter because gender-inequitable norms are one of the strongest predictors of gender-based violence. In societies where both men and women more strongly endorse beliefs such as “a wife should obey her husband,” rates of physical and sexual intimate partner violence are substantially higher, even after controlling for income and education [Heise and Kotsadam (2015)]. The violence stemming from the gendered norm is further exacerbated by patriarchal ideology; those holding more patriarchal attitudes are more likely to report perpetrating violence against partners, and thus using violence as a tool to maintain the gendered status quo [Fulu et al. (2013)].

Among adolescents, the issue of gender-based violence, which had not yet been resolved, has returned to schools. Under the influence of the gender equity backlash, the rapid diffusion of online “manfluencer” content can translate into in-person harassment of girls and female teachers, as boys import misogynistic scripts from the internet into the classroom [Wescott et al. (2024)]. Boys with more inequitable gender attitudes are more likely to excuse dating violence and sexual coercion, while girls in the same peer environments report higher rates of harassment and fear [Australia’s National Research Organisation for Women’s Safety (ANROWS) (2019)]. In parallel, harmful masculine norms captured by the so-called “Man Box” – encouraging aggression, emotional suppression and control over women – are associated with elevated rates of violence, accidents, suicide and mental-health problems [Fleming et al. (2020)].

The cumulative effect is not only a crisis of trust between young men and women, but also a significant drain on public resources. International organizations estimate that gender-based violence typically costs countries between 1–2% of GDP each year once lost output, healthcare, policing and justice system expenditures are taken into account [OECD (2023)]. Within the European Union alone, the annual cost of gender-based violence has been estimated at around EUR 366 billion, of which violence against women accounts for roughly EUR 289 billion and intimate partner violence accounts for almost half. School-related gender-based violence is estimated to cost low- and middle-income countries about USD 17 billion per year in lost educational attainment and future earnings European Institute for Gender Equality (2021). The estimated economic costs of the “man-box” problem are at least USD 15 billion per year in the United States alone [Heilman et al. (2017)]. These numbers suggest that youth gender polarization, when it entrenches acceptance of violence, undermines both human capital formation and the fiscal space available for other social priorities—in other words, it is part of the same structural misallocation described above.

3.2 Evidence on gender-expansive early education

So how did all this begin? Human cognition of society and surroundings unfolds through a gradual, cyclical process; it is not as though boys and girls suddenly awoke one day convinced they must adhere to gendered roles. The influence of norms on individuals commences far earlier than many suppose: by age six, children already

exhibit biased beliefs about boys' versus girls' intelligence and roles [Nugroho et al. (2022)]. A recent research pins down a gender gap in children's math ability increased with schooling rather than with age. Although boys and girls exhibit similar mathematical abilities prior to primary school enrollment, a gender gap favouring boys becomes highly significant after merely four months of schooling, influenced by teacher practices, classroom interactions, or peer norms [Martinot et al. (2025)].

If the harm has already been done at such an early stage, why can we not adopt a "prevention is better than cure" approach to tackle the root cause rather than merely treating the symptoms? For instance, exposing children to alternative possibilities before gendered stereotypes have solidified. After all, throughout the rest of their lives, individuals and indeed society at large will persistently reinforce expectations of "how a boy/girl ought to be".

Gender-expansive early education curricula, basically treating preschool as a preventative intervention, explicitly question gendered norm scripts. They aim to weaken the link between "boy/girl" and a narrow set of traits, toys, or life paths. The interventions in preschools have used a mix of: (i) classroom environments that avoid gendered colour-coding and toy segregation; (ii) pedagogical routines that encourage children to play and collaborate across gender lines; and (iii) explicit discussion or stories that present counter-stereotypical role models (e.g. male carers, female engineers) [Shutts et al. (2017); Nugroho et al. (2022); Segura-Nebot et al. (2025); Gulcicek and Tantekin Erden (2024)].

Short-run impacts on stereotypes and peer relations

Contrary to what many people feared, the intervention is not about erasing identity; it is about breaking the automatic link between "this label" and "this very narrow life script." Gender-expansive education doesn't make children "forget" they are boys or girls; it just makes those categories less bossy. In the Swedish gender-neutral preschool, kids still recognized who was a boy and who was a girl, but they were much less likely to say "only boys can do this job" or "this toy is for girls." Compared with children in regular preschools, they were more willing to say that both boys and girls could be truck drivers, carers or scientists, and they were more open to the idea that anyone could play with any toy [Shutts et al. (2017)]. Similar patterns show up in experiments from Türkiye and Spain: a few weeks of gender-neutral activities or counter-stereotypical storybooks are enough to shift children away from rigid "this is for my gender only" answers and toward more flexible attributions of roles and activities, and these effects persist beyond the final lesson [Gulcicek and Tantekin Erden (2024); Segura-Nebot et al. (2025)]. What doesn't change is their basic awareness of gender: they still spontaneously notice whether someone is a boy or a girl. Compared with "no treatment," where stereotypes simply harden with age, these classrooms bend the curve while identities remain intact.

The same interventions quietly rewire the social map of the classroom. In a conventional preschool, the playground often looks like two camps: boys mostly playing with boys, girls mostly with girls, and anyone who crosses the line risks being laughed at. In the Swedish study, children in the gender-pedagogy preschool were noticeably more willing to choose unfamiliar other-gender peers as play partners than

children in typical schools, suggesting that mixed-gender friendship felt normal rather than transgressive [[Shutts et al. \(2017\)](#)]. The narrative-based programs in Spain and the gender-neutral activity program in Türkiye go a step further: after hearing stories and doing activities where boys care for dolls or girls wield tools, children become less likely to exclude a peer “because that’s a girl’s game” or “a boy’s job,” and boys who want to engage in stereotypically “feminine” play face less ridicule from classmates [[Segura-Nebot et al. \(2025\)](#); [Gulcicek and Tantekin Erden \(2024\)](#)]. In other words, gender-expansive pedagogy does not just clean up what children say on stereotype checklists; it widens the kinds of friendships and collaborations that are socially acceptable in the room. For my purposes in this brief, this matters because it hints at a different future equilibrium: one where both girls and boys can experiment with “taboo” roles early on, without paying an immediate social cost from their peers.

Links to later attitudes and gender-based violence

The preschool evidence I have discussed so far mainly shows that gender-expansive environments can loosen children’s stereotypes and widen their cross-gender friendships. On its own, that does not yet prove that a four-year-old in a gender-neutral classroom will grow up to reject gender-based violence. However, work on older children and adolescents suggests that gender norms learned in school are precisely the levers that later programs target when they try to reduce violence. In particular, programs which explicitly challenge rigid gender norms, teach respect and consent, and involve peers and families, for example Good School Toolkit in Uganda or Shifting Boundaries in US middle schools, produce measurable reductions in physical, emotional and sexual violence, as well as more equitable attitudes among both boys and girls [[Villardón-Gallego et al. \(2023\)](#)].

In that sense, gender-expansive preschool can be thought of as clearing the field of stones, while later primary and secondary school programs build the fence that protects against concrete forms of abuse. The early years interventions I highlight here mainly operate on the “stones” — they make it less natural to think “boys don’t cry, girls don’t lead,” and they normalize cooperation across gender lines.

The violence-prevention programs reviewed in the GBV literature then use that same terrain — norms, peer dynamics, expectations about relationships — to teach explicit skills around consent, non-violence and bystander intervention. What we do not yet have is a 20-year follow-up experiment that connects a specific preschool gender-expansive curriculum to adult GBV outcomes. So the claim I make in this brief is more modest but still policy-relevant: early gender-expansive education is a low-cost upstream investment that shapes the very norms and peer patterns that, in older cohorts, we already know can be leveraged to reduce gender-based violence. It prepares a more flexible, less polarized cohort for the downstream programs that directly target violence.

4 Policy Recommendation

4.1 Integrate gender-expansive pedagogy into public preschool curricula

Canada is in the middle of a major institutional redesign in early childhood education and care, with the Canada-wide Early Learning and Child Care (ELCC) agreements and the move toward \$10-a-day childcare committing substantial long-run public resources to the 0–5 age range [[Department of Finance Canada \(2021\)](#)]. These reforms provide a natural vehicle to embed a more deliberate, gender-expansive approach in provincial preschool curricula.

The international evidence reviewed above suggests that gender-expansive and gender-neutral practices in early childhood settings are able to reduce rigid gender stereotyping and increase cross-gender cooperation among young children, without erasing gender as a category. Interventions that (i) avoid gendered colour-coding and toy segregation; (ii) structure pedagogical routines that encourage children to play and collaborate across gender lines; and (iii) explicitly use discussion or stories that present counter-stereotypical role models (e.g. male carers, female engineers). These programs shift how meaningful gender is for sorting people and activities, without denying that gender exists.

4.2 Provide adolescents with better “contact points” and realistic life-course information

Early childhood is not the only margin through which policy can influence the emerging gender divide. By adolescence, many young people are already immersed in highly gendered online environments where cross-gender contact is structured as adversarial—comment wars, mocking reaction videos, and “us versus them” dating narratives [[Gámez-Guadix et al. \(2023\)](#)]. From the perspective of intergroup contact theory, this is precisely the sort of bad contact that tends to harden prejudice rather than soften it: unequal status, competitive framing and hostile group norms [[Barlow et al. \(2025\)](#)].

Within schools, policy can partially rebalance this by creating better-designed points of contact between boys and girls and by giving students more realistic information about the economic and emotional consequences of different family and career arrangements. Concretely, this might include:

- Project-based learning and extracurricular activities where mixed-gender teams work toward common goals under cooperative, non-hierarchical norms, rather than competitively pitting boys and girls against each other;
- Systematic exposure to role models in atypical gendered occupations: men in nursing, early childhood education and social work; women in STEM, skilled trades and leadership;
- Age-appropriate financial literacy modules on “the economics of life choices,” in which students work through scenarios comparing dual-earner and single-earner households, unpaid care responsibilities, pension accumulation and re-entry into

the labour market after career breaks, framed in gender-neutral terms but explicitly discussing how traditional gender roles shift bargaining power and vulnerability.

These modules act as primary prevention infrastructure by broadening adolescents' perceived choice sets and making the long-run consequences of gendered roles like "tradwife" and hyper-masculine scripts more transparent, they reduce the likelihood that young adults will lock themselves into one-earner dependency or hyper-fragile breadwinner identities that later translate into higher demands on the welfare state and justice system.

4.3 Acknowledge limitations, risks, and the need for rigorous evaluation

Two important limitations of the current evidence base need to be acknowledged upfront. First, most studies of gender-expansive/gender-transformative education, whether in preschool or later school years, measure outcomes such as stereotypes, peer relations and self-reported attitudes over months or a few years. There is very little direct causal evidence tracking cohorts from early childhood through to adult labour-market outcomes, intimate-partner relationships or political attitudes. It would therefore be misleading to promise that a preschool curriculum change today will mechanically deliver lower gender-based violence or higher female labour-force participation twenty years from now. What the evidence supports is a more modest claim: these interventions reliably make children's gender schemas more flexible and their peer interactions less segregated in the short run, which are theoretically plausible precursors of better cooperation and lower acceptance of violence later in life.

Second, the most carefully evaluated interventions are small-scale and typically implemented by highly motivated educators under research conditions in Sweden, Türkiye, Spain and a handful of other contexts. Their effects may attenuate when scaled up across diverse Canadian settings with varying levels of teacher capacity and parental support. This is an argument for embedding monitoring and evaluation into policy design, not for inaction.

Beyond evidentiary limits, there are political and implementation risks. Gender-expansive pedagogy can easily be misrepresented in public debate as "ideological indoctrination," particularly when it touches on gender identity or challenges highly traditional family models. Social media platforms, whose business models reward polarizing and emotionally charged content, are unlikely to be natural allies; indeed, they may amplify backlash narratives. These risks are not reasons to avoid action, but they do require careful framing.

To conclude, the attraction of the proposed package is that it targets a structural misallocation at relatively low marginal cost. Canada is already investing heavily in early learning and child care; adding a content layer that nudges norms toward more cooperative, less zero-sum gender relations is inexpensive compared with the long-run fiscal burden of gender-based violence, underused female talent and burned-out young men. Framed and evaluated correctly, gender-expansive education is not about scripting private lives from above, but about loosening the grip of norms and feeds that quietly narrow life chances—so that when the next generation chooses how to love,

work and care, they do so with fuller information and a wider set of real options.

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